Even before the arrival of Europeans in America, there was an indigenous population, called Native Americans (they used to be referred to as 'Red Indians'; it is now considered demeaning, and historians do not use this term any more), spread over the vast American continent. They belonged to various tribes and many of them were at war with each other. Besides they refused to work under conditions of slavery. Through a combination of violence and diplomacy Europeans conquered and defeated many of these tribes. Greatly reduced in numbers today they live in various reserves.



Native Americans

Americans did not have representation in the British Parliament.

The Sugar Act of 1764 prohibited and imposed duties on molasses, wines, silks, coffee and other luxury items. As the Act was enforced ruthlessly, it led to protests by merchants in legislatures and town meetings. The preamble of the Sugar Act provided the slogan 'No Taxation without representation'. Soon the Currency Act was passed that insisted on colonies repaying the debt only in gold or silver. It was a huge burden on the colonial economy. The Quartering Act of 1765 required the colonies to pay for the cost of keeping British troops in America. The Stamp Act (1765) required that many printed materials in the colonies be produced on stamped paper produced in London, carrying an embossed revenue stamp.

Townshend Acts

The British Finance Minister Charles Townshend introduced new duties on imports in 1767, known as the Townshend Acts. They introduced duties on imports to colonies such as glass, paper, paint, lead and tea. Further, the British officers were empowered to search homes and businesses for smuggled or illegal goods.

There were widespread protests against the Townshend Acts. Merchants of Boston organized boycott of British goods. Soon other colonies joined the protest. The women formed their own organization called the 'Daughters of Liberty'. The leaders insisted on constitutional methods and asked the people to remain calm. The British mobilized more troops to encounter the protests. This angered the people further. In March 1770, resentment rose in Boston, when troops fired on a crowd which had thrown snowballs at them. There was firing by the troops resulting in many deaths. This incident is known as the Boston Massacre. It led to intense anti-British propaganda through newspapers, posters and pamphlets.

As a result of protests and boycotts, the British Parliament repealed the Townshend Acts. However, it retained the tax on tea, with the intention of encouraging the business of the East India Company by making it easy for it to take its tea to America and sell it there. This harmed the local tea trade and so it was decided to boycott this foreign tea.

Boston Tea Party

In many places the colonists obstructed the import of tea. In Charlestown, they unloaded the tea and let it rot in the dock. In New York and Philadelphia ships carrying tea were blocked. In December 1773, a group of men disguised themselves as Native Americans boarded the cargo vessels and threw the tea overboard.

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